

# CLOTHING MANUFACTURING

## Business Guide for Startups

*From Fabric to Fashion — A Complete Roadmap for Entrepreneurs*

**1998**

Founded

**300 pcs**

Min. Order

**14 days**

Sample Time

**200+**

Brands Served

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**Written by: SDF Clothing**

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# Foreword by Chowdhury Remon

*Founder & CEO, SDF Clothing | Garment Manufacturing Expert Since 1998*

When I started SDF Clothing in 1998, the global fashion industry worked very differently. Large brands dominated manufacturing relationships, and small designers or startup labels had almost no access to professional, certified garment factories. The minimum order quantities were too high, the processes too opaque, and the support for new brands virtually nonexistent.

Over 25 years later, I am proud to say that SDF Clothing has become a bridge between startup fashion brands and world-class manufacturing. We have served over 200 international brands — from first-time founders placing their very first order of 300 pieces, to established labels ordering every season. Through every partnership, I have seen the same challenge repeat itself: founders with great ideas, strong design instincts, and real market potential — but limited knowledge of how manufacturing actually works.

That gap in knowledge costs brands money, time, and sometimes the business itself. A wrong fabric choice, a misunderstood tech pack, a missed quality inspection, or incorrect export paperwork can unravel months of work and thousands of dollars.

This eBook is my answer to that problem. Written from 25+ years of hands-on experience on the factory floor, in the dyeing shed, in shipping containers, and in meetings with buyers from London, Paris, New York, and Sydney — this guide covers everything a startup clothing brand needs to know to work successfully with a garment manufacturer.

Whether you are launching your first t-shirt brand, building a premium athleisure line, or scaling a sustainable fashion label, the knowledge in these pages will save you from the most common and costly mistakes in clothing manufacturing.

Read it carefully. Refer back to it often. And when you are ready to start — reach out to us. We are here to help you turn your idea into a garment the world can wear.

## **Chowdhury Remon**

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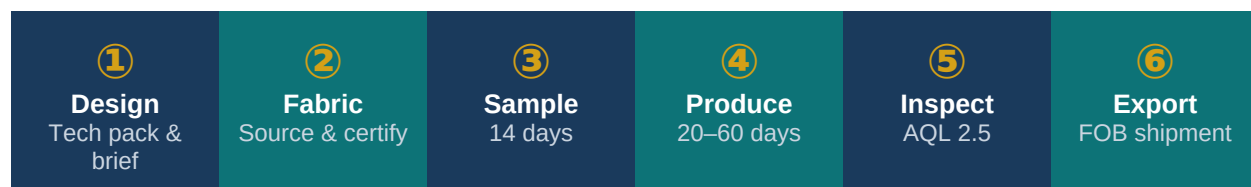
# Chapter 1: Introduction

## The Global Apparel Industry

The global apparel industry generates over \$1.5 trillion in annual revenue and employs hundreds of millions of people across the world. Fashion is more than clothing — it is an expression of culture, identity, and economy. Every garment tells a story of raw materials transformed through skill, technology, and creativity into products that people wear every single day.

The industry spans a complex global supply chain — from cotton farms and synthetic fiber factories to cutting and sewing facilities, packaging plants, shipping lines, and ultimately retail shelves in cities around the world. Understanding this chain is the first and most important step for any entrepreneur entering the clothing business.

## The Manufacturing Journey at a Glance



## Why Bangladesh is a Global Hub

Bangladesh stands as the world's second-largest garment exporter, producing over \$40 billion worth of apparel annually for major markets including the EU, USA, UK, Canada, and Australia. The advantages are compelling:

- Production costs 30–40% lower than China and Vietnam
- 4 million skilled garment workers — one of the world's largest talent pools
- Duty-free access to EU and UK under EBA and DCTS trade agreements
- Established infrastructure — Chittagong and Dhaka ports, logistics networks
- Compliance with GOTS, OEKO-TEX, BSCI, SEDEX, and ISO standards
- Strong supplier ecosystem for fabrics, trims, and accessories — all sourced locally

## About SDF Clothing

SDF Clothing has been manufacturing garments for global fashion brands since 1998 — over 25 years of production excellence. Based in Dhaka, Bangladesh, SDF operates a vertically integrated facility handling fabric sourcing, sample development, bulk production, embroidery, printing, quality inspection, packaging, and export — all under one roof, with no outsourcing.

|                             |                                 |                                |                                |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>1998</b><br>Year Founded | <b>300 pcs</b><br>Minimum Order | <b>14 days</b><br>Sample Ready | <b>&lt;0.8%</b><br>Defect Rate |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|

SDF Clothing works with first-time founders and established brands alike — from startups testing their first design to labels ordering every season across multiple styles. The company is GOTS certified, OEKO-TEX compliant, and follows BSCI and SEDEX standards for ethical manufacturing.

**"Our mission is to make professional garment manufacturing accessible to every fashion entrepreneur — regardless of order size or experience level." — Chowdhury Remon, Founder & CEO**

## Chapter 2: Starting the Business

### Understanding Minimum Order Quantity (MOQ)

The first question every startup brand asks is: how many pieces do I have to order? The answer is the Minimum Order Quantity — MOQ. This is the smallest number of garments a factory will produce for a single style in one production run. MOQ exists because factories have fixed setup costs: pattern cutting, sample making, machine setup, and fabric procurement. These costs must spread across enough units to be viable.

**SDF Clothing MOQ: 300 pieces per style. Split across sizes or colors within the same style.**

### Production Models: Which One is Right for You?

|                                              |                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>OEM (Original Equipment Manufacturer)</b> | You provide complete designs. Factory manufactures exactly to your specs. Full branding and creative control. Best for brands with finished tech packs.                     |
| <b>ODM (Original Design Manufacturer)</b>    | Factory provides ready-made designs that you brand as your own. Faster to market. Lower design cost. Less unique.                                                           |
| <b>Private Label</b>                         | Factory produces standard items. You apply your brand, labels, and packaging. Good for testing a market with minimal investment.                                            |
| <b>CMT (Cut, Make, Trim)</b>                 | You supply the fabric. Factory cuts, sews, trims, and packs. Lowest cost per unit. Most control over material sourcing. No MOQ when you supply fabric.                      |
| <b>Bespoke Development</b>                   | SDF turns rough concepts or sketches into production-ready garments. Includes tech pack creation, fabric consultation, and sample development. Ideal for first-time brands. |

### The Tech Pack: Your Manufacturing Blueprint

A tech pack (technical package) is the single most important document in clothing manufacturing. It is the complete specification sheet that tells the factory exactly how to make your garment. Never place a production order without a complete, approved tech pack. It must include:

- Flat sketches — front, back, and close-up detail views of all design elements
- Technical measurements — for all sizes in your range, with tolerance specifications
- Fabric specifications — type, composition, weight (GSM), color references (Pantone codes)
- Trim details — all labels, buttons, zippers, elastics, drawstrings with specific references
- Stitch specifications — stitch type and stitch count per inch for each seam
- Construction notes — seam allowances, finishing methods, special handling instructions

- Artwork files — print-ready artwork for embroidery, screen print, or digital prints
- Packaging instructions — how to fold, tag, polybag, and box the finished garment

**i** SDF Clothing's team can help first-time brands build tech packs from rough sketches — no technical background required.

## Sampling Process: From Idea to Approved Prototype

|                                    |                                                                                          |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Proto Sample</b>                | First rough sample to test design concept. May use substitute fabrics. Cost: \$50–\$100. |
| <b>Fit Sample</b>                  | Used to test garment fit on a fit model. Measurements checked and adjusted.              |
| <b>Salesman Sample (SMS)</b>       | Production-quality sample. Used for selling to buyers or trade shows.                    |
| <b>Pre-Production Sample (PPS)</b> | Final approval sample before mass production. Must match bulk exactly. Never skip this.  |

**i** SDF Clothing produces samples in 14 days. Samples are free for confirmed orders. Revisions available up to 10 rounds.

## Payment Terms

Understanding payment terms protects you and ensures a smooth production process. SDF Clothing's standard payment terms are:

- 30% deposit — required to start sampling and secure your production slot
- 70% balance — due before shipment (after final inspection is passed)

Payment methods accepted include international bank wire transfer (TT), PayPal, and Wise. For large orders, Letter of Credit (LC) arrangements can be discussed.

# Chapter 3: Fabric & Yarn

## Why Fabric Choice Is Your Most Important Decision

Fabric is the foundation of every garment. Your fabric choice determines how the garment looks, feels, performs, and lasts. It affects your production cost, your sustainability story, your target market positioning, and your compliance with import regulations. Understanding fabric basics is non-negotiable for any clothing brand owner.

## Knit Fabrics — Stretch & Comfort

| Type                      | Best For                       | GSM Range | Key Features                   |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------|--------------------------------|
| Single Jersey             | T-shirts, basics               | 140–200   | Lightweight, soft, most common |
| Double Jersey / Interlock | Premium t-shirts, baby clothes | 200–280   | Heavier, stable, less curl     |
| Rib Knit                  | Cuffs, collars, waistbands     | 180–280   | Very stretchy, recovers shape  |
| French Terry              | Sweatshirts, joggers           | 240–350   | Loop inside, smooth outside    |
| Fleece                    | Hoodies, winter basics         | 280–400   | Brushed interior, warm         |
| Pique                     | Polo shirts, sportswear        | 180–260   | Textured surface, breathable   |
| Interlock + Lycra         | Activewear, leggings           | 180–280   | 4-way stretch, shape retention |

## Woven Fabrics — Structure & Durability

|        |                           |             |                                       |
|--------|---------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------|
| Denim  | Jeans, jackets            | 8oz–14oz    | Classic twill weave, rigid or stretch |
| Poplin | Shirts, blouses           | 80–120 GSM  | Smooth, crisp, lightweight            |
| Twill  | Chinos, workwear          | 200–400 GSM | Diagonal weave, soft drape            |
| Oxford | Casual shirts             | 150–220 GSM | Basket weave, durable, textured       |
| Canvas | Bags, workwear, outerwear | 300–600 GSM | Heavy-duty, structured                |
| Linen  | Summer wear, resort       | 120–200 GSM | Natural, breathable,                  |



|                        |                  |             |                                  |
|------------------------|------------------|-------------|----------------------------------|
|                        |                  |             | slight texture                   |
| <b>Viscose / Rayon</b> | Dresses, blouses | 100–160 GSM | Fluid drape, smooth, lightweight |

## Sustainable Fabric Options

|                                  |            |                                                                           |
|----------------------------------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Organic Cotton</b>            | GOTS / OCS | No synthetic pesticides. Lower environmental impact. Premium positioning. |
| <b>Recycled Polyester (rPET)</b> | GRS        | Made from post-consumer plastic bottles. Reduces petroleum use.           |
| <b>Tencel / Lyocell</b>          | FSC        | From sustainably harvested wood pulp. Biodegradable, soft.                |
| <b>Bamboo</b>                    | OEKO-TEX   | Fast-growing, renewable. Soft and antibacterial.                          |
| <b>Modal</b>                     | OEKO-TEX   | From beech trees. Super soft, breathable, durable.                        |
| <b>Hemp</b>                      | N/A        | Minimal water and no pesticides needed. Very durable.                     |
| <b>Deadstock Fabric</b>          | N/A        | Leftover fabric from other production. Zero new resource use.             |

## Understanding GSM — Fabric Weight Guide

|                     |                  |                                         |
|---------------------|------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>90–140 GSM</b>   | Very lightweight | Summer t-shirts, underlayers, vest tops |
| <b>150–180 GSM</b>  | Standard weight  | Everyday t-shirts, casual basics        |
| <b>190–220 GSM</b>  | Mid-weight       | Premium t-shirts, polo shirts           |
| <b>250–300 GSM</b>  | Heavy            | Hoodies, fleece, sweatshirts            |
| <b>300–400+ GSM</b> | Very heavy       | Outerwear, denim jackets, workwear      |

## Certifications That Matter

|                     |                                 |                                                                       |
|---------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>GOTS</b>         | Global Organic Textile Standard | Organic fiber content + responsible manufacturing. EU-recognized.     |
| <b>OEKO-TEX 100</b> | Standard 100 by OEKO-TEX        | Tests for harmful substances. Safe for skin contact including babies. |
| <b>GRS</b>          | Global Recycled Standard        | Verifies recycled content in fabrics and trims. Chain of custody.     |
| <b>BCI</b>          | Better Cotton Initiative        | Supports sustainable cotton farming. Not                              |

|                 |                       |                                                             |
|-----------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
|                 |                       | certified organic.                                          |
| <b>Bluesign</b> | Bluesign Technologies | Chemical, water, energy, and occupational health standards. |

# Chapter 4: Knitting, Weaving & Dyeing

## Fabric Construction: Knit vs. Woven

All fabrics fall into two fundamental construction types — knit and woven. This distinction determines stretch, drape, structure, and which garment types a fabric is suitable for. Choosing the wrong construction type for a garment is one of the most common and costly mistakes startup brands make.

|               |                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| KNIT FABRICS  | Made by interlocking loops of yarn. Naturally stretchy. Comfortable and casual. Examples: jersey, french terry, fleece, rib, pique.    |
| WOVEN FABRICS | Made by interlacing yarns at right angles. Structured, stable, minimal stretch. Examples: denim, poplin, twill, canvas, linen, oxford. |

## Dyeing: Adding Color to Fabric or Garment

Dyeing is the process of applying color to yarn, fabric, or finished garment. It is one of the most technically complex and environmentally impactful processes in garment manufacturing. Choosing the right dyeing method affects appearance, cost, sustainability profile, and colorfastness.

|                |                                                                                                      |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Piece Dyeing   | Fabric dyed after weaving/knitting. Most common. Good for solid colors. Cost-effective.              |
| Yarn Dyeing    | Yarn dyed before weaving. Used for stripes, checks, gingham patterns.                                |
| Garment Dyeing | Finished garments dyed. Unique tonal look, soft feel. Slight size variation expected.                |
| Bleach Wash    | Fabric or garment treated with bleach for faded, vintage effect. Common in streetwear and denim.     |
| Over-Dyeing    | Garment dyed second color on top of original. Creates depth and unique tones.                        |
| Vintage Wash   | Combined bleach, stonewash, and enzymatic treatments for aged appearance.                            |
| Enzyme Wash    | Biological treatment softens fabric and creates subtle worn look without harsh bleach.               |
| Acid Wash      | High-contrast bleach pattern. Creates marble or cloud effect. Classic streetwear and punk aesthetic. |
| Silicon Wash   | Silicone-based treatment creates extremely soft, peach-skin surface texture.                         |
| Garment Dye    | Piece dyed after garment construction for a unique, slightly uneven tonal effect.                    |

|                   |                                                                                |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sand Blast</b> | High-pressure sand abrasion on denim. Creates localized worn patch appearance. |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## Eco-Friendly Dyeing Practices

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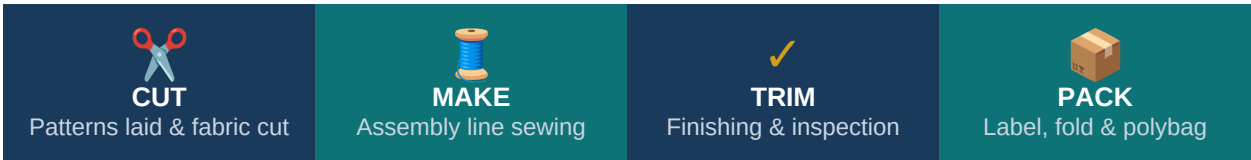
- Low-impact reactive dyes: Require significantly less water and salt than conventional dyes
- Waterless dyeing: Uses CO2 or air as the medium — eliminates wastewater entirely
- Closed-loop water systems: Wastewater treated, recycled, and reused within the factory
- Natural dyes: Plant or mineral-derived. Fully biodegradable. Limited to earthy color range
- OEKO-TEX certified dyes: Free from harmful substances, tested for skin safety

**i** SDF Clothing uses OEKO-TEX certified dyes and operates an Effluent Treatment Plant (ETP) to treat all wastewater before discharge — in compliance with Bangladesh environmental regulations and EU buyer requirements.

# Chapter 5: Cutting, Sewing & Finishing

## The CMT Process

CMT — Cut, Make, Trim — is the backbone of garment construction. It describes the three core stages of turning fabric into a finished garment. Understanding CMT is fundamental to understanding production costs, lead times, and where quality issues most commonly arise.



## Print Techniques

|                         |                                                                                          |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Screen Print            | Up to 8 colors. Water-based or plastisol inks. Best for bold, graphic designs on cotton. |
| DTF (Direct to Film)    | Full color, photographic quality. Works on all fabrics. No minimum quantity.             |
| DTG (Direct to Garment) | Inkjet directly onto fabric. Full color. Best on 100% cotton. Small runs.                |
| Sublimation             | All-over print. Vivid colors. Polyester fabrics only. Used in activewear and sportswear. |
| Heat Transfer (Vinyl)   | Complex shapes and small runs. Layered vinyl applied by heat press.                      |
| Discharge Print         | Removes dye from fabric for soft hand feel. Vintage look. 100% cotton only.              |
| Pigment Print           | Soft hand feel. Water-based. Vintage wash compatible. Eco-friendly options available.    |
| Foil Print              | Metallic gold, silver, or custom foil colors. Spot application for premium effect.       |
| Puff Print              | Raised 3D effect. Spot application on any fabric. Popular in streetwear.                 |
| Rubber / Silicone Print | Tactile raised print. Common in activewear and premium streetwear branding.              |
| Reflective Print        | Safety and streetwear. ANSI compliant options available.                                 |

## Embroidery Options

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|                           |                                                                                  |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Flat Embroidery</b>    | Standard thread embroidery. Up to 15 thread colors per design. Any placement.    |
| <b>3D Puff Embroidery</b> | Raised foam under thread creates bold 3D effect. Common on caps and chest logos. |
| <b>Applique</b>           | Fabric cut and sewn onto garment. Creates layered, textured design effect.       |
| <b>Chain Stitch</b>       | Single thread vintage outline style. Authentic workwear and denim look.          |
| <b>Chenille</b>           | Thick yarn — varsity style. College, streetwear, and Americana aesthetic.        |
| <b>Sequin Embroidery</b>  | Individual sequins stitched by machine. Occasion wear and festival fashion.      |
| <b>Laser Etching</b>      | Precision design on denim, leather, and synthetics. Clean, modern look.          |
| <b>Woven Badge</b>        | Separate woven label sewn or heat-applied. Used for brand patches and badges.    |

## Finishing Treatments

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|                                  |                                                                        |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Soft Touch / Silicon Wash</b> | Chemical treatment produces silky, luxurious hand feel.                |
| <b>Enzyme Wash</b>               | Biological softening. Slight fade and worn look without harsh bleach.  |
| <b>Stone Wash</b>                | Pumice stone washing. Heavy texture and fade. Classic denim treatment. |
| <b>Vintage Wash</b>              | Combined stone, bleach, and enzyme process for authentic aged look.    |
| <b>Acid Wash</b>                 | High-contrast bleach marble pattern. Streetwear and punk aesthetic.    |
| <b>Anti-Pilling Finish</b>       | Prevents fiber balls forming on fabric surface over time.              |
| <b>Anti-Bacterial Finish</b>     | Inhibits bacterial growth. Used in activewear and medical garments.    |
| <b>DWR Water Repellent</b>       | Durable water repellent coating for outerwear and performance wear.    |

# Chapter 6: Packaging & Branding

## Why Branding Starts Inside the Garment

Two identical t-shirts — one branded, one not — can sell at dramatically different price points. Your brand is your promise. It communicates quality, values, and identity. Every touchpoint matters: the label inside a garment, the tag attached to it, the polybag it arrives in, and the box it is shipped in. Great branding transforms a transaction into an experience.

## Labels: Every Type Explained

|                     |                                                                                               |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Main / Brand Label  | Sewn at back neck. Shows brand name and logo. Woven, printed, or heat transfer.               |
| Care Label          | Required by law in all markets. Washing, drying, ironing instructions using ISO symbols.      |
| Size Label          | Indicates garment size. Usually sewn below main label or on a side seam.                      |
| Country of Origin   | Required for export. States where the garment was made: 'Made in Bangladesh'.                 |
| Composition Label   | States fabric content: '100% Cotton' or '60% Cotton, 40% Polyester'. EU/UK legal requirement. |
| Heat Transfer Label | Printed directly onto fabric interior. No visible label — premium, seamless feel.             |
| Side Seam Label     | Narrow printed label sewn into side seam. Discreet. Common in premium basics.                 |
| Woven Label         | Brand name or logo woven into fabric. Premium look and feel. Durable.                         |

## Trims: The Details That Define Quality

|                  |                                                                                                    |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Zippers          | YKK (premium) or generic. Nylon, metal, invisible, waterproof. Branded pullers and tape available. |
| Buttons          | Resin, metal, wood, shell, or branded with logo. Various finishes and diameters.                   |
| Rivets & Eyelets | Metal reinforcement for stress points on denim, bags, and workwear.                                |
| Elastics         | Waistband, cuff, and bra-strap. Branded print on elastic available for premium brands.             |
| Drawstrings      | Cotton, polyester, flat and round. Matched to garment color. Custom tips available.                |

|               |                                                                     |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Velcro</b> | Hook and loop closure. Branded and unbranded. All widths available. |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|

## Packaging Options

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|                                 |                                                                                             |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Printed Polybag</b>          | Standard protective packaging. Custom printed with your logo and branding.                  |
| <b>Eco Mailer Bag</b>           | Compostable or recycled material. D2C e-commerce packaging with sustainability credentials. |
| <b>Tissue Paper</b>             | Branded or colored tissue wrapping inside packaging. Adds unboxing premium feel.            |
| <b>Rigid Box</b>                | Luxury packaging for premium garments, gifting, and high-end D2C brands.                    |
| <b>Folding Box</b>              | Printed card stock box. Brand story, QR codes, and design on all panels.                    |
| <b>Branded Elastic Band</b>     | Folds and secures garments inside boxes. No pins — clean, professional presentation.        |
| <b>Stickers &amp; Wax Seals</b> | Branded closure for tissue paper and mailer bags. Finishing touch for premium D2C.          |

**Eco-friendly packaging — recycled materials, compostable bags, soy-based inks — is increasingly expected by conscious consumers and required by EU sustainability regulations from 2026.**



# Chapter 7: Quality Control

## Quality Control is Non-Negotiable

Quality failures in garment manufacturing are costly — not just in returned goods and refunds, but in brand reputation damage that can take years to repair. Professional quality control is systematic, documented, and conducted at multiple stages — not just at the end of production.

|                                           |                                    |                                             |                                         |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>AQL 2.5</b><br>SDF Inspection Standard | <b>&lt;0.8%</b><br>SDF Defect Rate | <b>2–4%</b><br>Industry Average Defect Rate | <b>3 stages</b><br>Quality Check Points |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|

## The AQL System Explained

AQL — Acceptable Quality Level — is the internationally standardized system for statistical sampling and inspection in manufacturing. AQL 2.5 means that in a statistically valid sample, no more than 2.5% of units may have defects before the batch is rejected. This is the industry standard for fashion garments.

|                |                                                                          |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>AQL 1.0</b> | Very strict. High-value items, medical garments, children's wear.        |
| <b>AQL 2.5</b> | Industry standard for fashion. Balance of thoroughness and practicality. |
| <b>AQL 4.0</b> | More lenient. Low-cost commodity items and bulk basics.                  |

## Three Categories of Defects

|                 |                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>CRITICAL</b> | Makes garment unsafe or unusable. Examples: sharp metal object embedded in fabric, toxic dye. Zero tolerance — entire batch rejected. |
| <b>MAJOR</b>    | Significantly affects appearance or function. Examples: wrong size, broken zipper, large stain, wrong color. Strictly controlled.     |
| <b>MINOR</b>    | Small imperfections, slight quality reduction. Examples: loose thread, minor misalignment. Limited tolerance under AQL 2.5.           |

## Four-Stage Quality Control Process

|                                                          |                                                            |                                                           |                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>①</b><br><b>PRE-PRODUCTION</b><br>Fabric & trim check | <b>②</b><br><b>DURING PRODUCTION</b><br>30% complete check | <b>③</b><br><b>FINAL INSPECTION</b><br>AQL 2.5 full check | <b>④</b><br><b>LOADING CHECK</b><br>Carton & container |
|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|

## Third-Party Inspection

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Third-party inspection by an independent international company provides buyers with credibility and documented proof of quality compliance. SDF Clothing welcomes and facilitates inspections by:

- SGS (Société Générale de Surveillance) — global leader in testing and inspection
- Bureau Veritas — international inspection, testing, and certification
- Intertek — 100+ countries, specialist in consumer goods compliance
- QIMA — specialist in consumer goods inspection across Asia

 *SDF Clothing allows access to any buyer-nominated third-party inspector at any stage of production. Inspection reports are provided to buyers upon request.*

## Chapter 8: Logistics & Export

### Understanding Incoterms

Incoterms (International Commercial Terms) define exactly who is responsible for what — costs, risks, and duties — at each stage of the international shipping journey. Choosing the right Incoterm protects your business and avoids expensive disputes.

|                                     |                                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>FOB (Free on Board)</b>          | Seller loads goods onto vessel at named port. Buyer takes risk from that point. Most common in Bangladesh garment trade. |
| <b>CIF (Cost Insurance Freight)</b> | Seller arranges and pays for shipping and insurance to buyer's destination port.                                         |
| <b>EXW (Ex Works)</b>               | Buyer collects goods from factory gate. Seller has minimum responsibility.                                               |
| <b>DDP (Delivered Duty Paid)</b>    | Seller delivers to buyer's address, all duties and taxes paid. Maximum seller responsibility.                            |

***i** SDF Clothing ships FOB from Chittagong Port (CGP) or Dhaka Inland Container Depot. All export documentation is handled by our team.*

### Required Export Documents

- Commercial Invoice — goods, quantities, unit prices, and total value for customs
- Packing List — carton-by-carton breakdown of styles, sizes, colors, weights, dimensions
- Bill of Lading (B/L) — issued by shipping company, required to claim goods at destination
- Certificate of Origin (CO) — proves goods were made in Bangladesh (Chamber of Commerce issued)
- GSP Form A / EUR.1 Certificate — enables duty-free import into EU and UK
- GOTS / OEKO-TEX Certificates — required by many EU and UK buyers for sustainable claims
- Test Reports — lab test results for fabric certifications and chemical compliance

### Duty-Free Benefits from Bangladesh

|                                   |                                    |                                 |                                       |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>0%</b><br>EU Import Duty (EBA) | <b>0%</b><br>UK Import Duty (DCTS) | <b>0%</b><br>Canada Duty (LDCT) | <b>9–12%</b><br>China/Vietnam EU Duty |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------|

|                       |                                                                                  |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>European Union</b> | EBA (Everything But Arms). Zero tariffs on garments. Requires EUR.1 certificate. |
| <b>United Kingdom</b> | DCTS (Developing Countries Trading Scheme). Post-Brexit preferential             |

|                  |                                                                                 |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                  | access.                                                                         |
| <b>Canada</b>    | LDCT (Least Developed Country Tariff). Zero duty on Bangladesh garment imports. |
| <b>Australia</b> | DFSP preferential tariff access for Bangladesh goods.                           |

## Shipping Options

|                            |                                                                                               |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sea Freight FCL</b>     | Full Container Load. 20ft or 40ft container. Best for large orders. 20–35 day transit.        |
| <b>Sea Freight LCL</b>     | Less than Container Load. Shared container. Good for medium orders. Slightly higher cost/CBM. |
| <b>Air Freight</b>         | 3–7 days to most destinations. Much more expensive. Use for urgent or high-value orders.      |
| <b>DHL / FedEx Courier</b> | Best for samples and small parcels. Door-to-door tracked. Expensive for commercial volumes.   |

## Production & Shipping Timeline

|                                                 |                                             |                                                 |                                                         |                                            |                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| <b>D1</b><br>Brief Sent<br>Email or<br>WhatsApp | <b>D2</b><br>Quote Ready<br>Within 48 hours | <b>D3–7</b><br>Tech Pack<br>Fabric<br>confirmed | <b>D14</b><br>Sample<br>Ready<br>Proto or fit<br>sample | <b>D20</b><br>Bulk Done<br>Up to 5,000 pcs | <b>D45</b><br>FOB Shipped<br>Chittagong port |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|

## Chapter 9: Tools & Calculators

### Digital Tools on sdf ltd.com

SDF Clothing's website provides a suite of free digital tools designed to help startup brands make accurate, informed decisions before placing an order. These tools reduce costly mistakes and save time — no registration required, no forms, instant results.

|                                   |                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>FOB Price Calculator</b>       | Estimates your garment cost based on fabric type, GSM, design complexity, and order quantity. Gives you COGS clarity before committing. |
| <b>MOQ Checker</b>                | Confirms if your planned order meets the 300-piece minimum. Shows how to split across sizes and colors.                                 |
| <b>Duty Savings Calculator</b>    | Calculates exactly how much import duty you save by sourcing from Bangladesh versus China, Vietnam, India, or Turkey.                   |
| <b>Fabric GSM Converter</b>       | Converts between fabric weight measurements. Helps select the right GSM for your garment and season.                                    |
| <b>AQL Sample Size Calculator</b> | Determines exactly how many units to inspect based on your order size and AQL level (2.5 standard).                                     |
| <b>HS Code Finder</b>             | Identifies the correct 6-digit Harmonized System tariff code for your garment — essential for accurate customs documentation.           |
| <b>Lead Time Planner</b>          | Maps your production timeline from order confirmation to shipment date based on style complexity and quantity.                          |
| <b>Carton Volume Calculator</b>   | Calculates CBM (cubic meters) for your shipment to estimate sea freight costs and container requirements.                               |
| <b>Manufacturer Match Tool</b>    | 3-question quiz that recommends whether OEM, ODM, Private Label, or CMT is the right production model for your brand.                   |

### How to Use the FOB Price Calculator

- Step 1: Select your garment type (t-shirt, hoodie, jacket, dress, etc.)
- Step 2: Choose your fabric type and GSM
- Step 3: Select design complexity — plain, printed, or embroidered
- Step 4: Enter your order quantity
- Step 5: Specify any special finishes or wash treatments
- Step 6: Calculator provides estimated FOB price range in USD per piece

**i** Calculator estimates are indicative. Actual price depends on current fabric market rates, confirmed trim specifications, and order quantity. Always request a formal written quotation from SDF Clothing before committing.

# Understanding HS Codes

Every product traded internationally requires a Harmonized System (HS) code — a standardized numerical code used by customs authorities worldwide. Incorrect HS codes on export documents can result in wrong duty rates, customs delays, or legal penalties. Common garment HS code prefixes:

|            |                                                                       |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chapter 61 | Knitted or crocheted clothing (t-shirts, hoodies, knitwear)           |
| Chapter 62 | Not knitted or crocheted (woven garments — shirts, trousers, jackets) |
| Chapter 63 | Textile made-up articles (bags, hats, accessories)                    |

Use the HS Code Finder at [sdfltd.com](https://sdfltd.com) to identify your exact code — it matters for duty rates, compliance, and accurate invoicing.

## Chapter 10: Challenges & Solutions

### The Reality of Manufacturing

No production journey is perfectly smooth. The brands that succeed are not those that avoid problems — they are those who anticipate them and solve them quickly. Below are the most common challenges startup brands face, and the practical solutions that experienced manufacturers use to address them.

|                           |                                                                         |                                                                                              |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Fabric Delays</b>      | Custom dyeing or specialty fabric lead times. Mill schedule conflicts.  | Order fabric 3 weeks ahead. Choose stock fabrics. Use SDF's in-house fabric inventory.       |
| <b>Quality Issues</b>     | Incomplete tech pack. Skipped sample approval. No mid-production check. | Complete tech pack. Approve PPS. Request DUPRO inspection at 30% completion.                 |
| <b>Wrong Measurements</b> | Size chart not communicated clearly. No tolerance specified.            | Provide graded size specs with tolerances. Approve fit sample on real body.                  |
| <b>Color Mismatch</b>     | Color described by name, not Pantone code. Dye batch variation.         | Always use Pantone codes. Approve lab dip before bulk dyeing. Dye tolerance $\pm 1$ Delta E. |
| <b>Communication Gaps</b> | Verbal agreements, no written confirmation. Multiple contacts involved. | All decisions in writing. One dedicated contact per account. Use SDF's client portal.        |
| <b>Shipping Delays</b>    | Freight booking too late. Port congestion. Document errors.             | Book freight 3 weeks before cargo ready date. Allow 2-week buffer in every timeline.         |
| <b>Cost Overruns</b>      | Hidden costs not itemized. Fabric price fluctuations. Currency changes. | Request itemized quote. Fix price in writing before production start. Factor all costs.      |
| <b>Customs Delays</b>     | Wrong HS code. Missing certificates. Incorrect invoice value.           | Use HS Code Finder. Prepare all documents in advance. Use SDF's export documentation team.   |

### Risk Management Checklist for Startups

- Always have a backup fabric option pre-approved before production starts
- Never skip the pre-production sample (PPS) — it is your last chance to correct mistakes
- Build 2–3 week buffers into every production timeline for your first orders
- Keep email records of every decision, change, and approval
- Understand your import duties and customs requirements before placing your order
- Do not plan around best-case timelines — plan around realistic worst-case scenarios

- Visit the factory for your first order if at all possible



# Chapter 11: Sustainability & Future Trends

## The Scale of Fashion's Environmental Impact

The clothing industry is one of the world's most polluting sectors. It produces 10% of global carbon emissions — more than international aviation and shipping combined. It consumes 79 trillion liters of water annually and generates 92 million tonnes of textile waste each year. Of the clothing produced globally, 87% ends up in landfill or incinerated.

These facts are driving a fundamental transformation in how garments are designed, produced, sold, and disposed of. Sustainability is no longer optional — it is becoming a baseline expectation from consumers, retailers, investors, and regulators. For startup brands, building sustainability into your brand from day one is both an ethical responsibility and a significant competitive advantage.

|                                                            |                                     |                                        |                                         |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>10%</b><br>Fashion's share of CO <sub>2</sub> emissions | <b>79T L</b><br>Water used annually | <b>92M T</b><br>Textile waste per year | <b>87%</b><br>Clothing sent to landfill |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|

## Factory Certifications That Matter

|                  |                                                                                                                |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>GOTS</b>      | Global Organic Textile Standard. Covers organic fiber content + environmental/social standards. EU-recognized. |
| <b>OEKO-TEX</b>  | Tests for harmful substances across the entire supply chain. Safe product guarantee.                           |
| <b>BSCI</b>      | Business Social Compliance Initiative. Labor rights, health and safety, environment.                           |
| <b>SEDEX</b>     | Supplier Ethical Data Exchange. Labor practices, health, safety, environment monitoring.                       |
| <b>ISO 14001</b> | Environmental Management System. Systematic approach to reducing environmental impact.                         |
| <b>LEED</b>      | Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design. Certifies green factory buildings.                              |
| <b>SA8000</b>    | Social Accountability standard. Child labor, forced labor, worker rights, health and safety.                   |

## EU Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) 2026

From 2026, the European Union's Extended Producer Responsibility regulations for textiles require brands selling clothing in the EU to be financially responsible for end-of-life management of their products — including collection, sorting, and recycling.

This regulation will significantly impact how garments must be designed. Key requirements include:

- Mono-material construction where possible (single fiber type easier to recycle)
- Avoiding mixed-material trims that contaminate recycling streams
- Product passports — digital records of garment composition and manufacturing data
- Minimum recycled content requirements increasing year on year
- Take-back program or partnership with certified textile recycling schemes

**i** Brands planning to sell in the EU should begin designing for EPR compliance now — brands that are ready early will have a significant competitive advantage from 2026.

## Future Trends Reshaping the Industry

|                                          |                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Digital Fashion &amp; 3D Sampling</b> | Virtual prototypes (CLO3D, Browzwear) reduce sample costs and carbon footprint. Full production without a physical sample possible. |
| <b>Supply Chain Traceability</b>         | Blockchain and QR code technology lets consumers scan a garment to see exactly where it was made, from fiber to factory.            |
| <b>On-Demand Manufacturing</b>           | Produce garments only after an order is placed. Eliminates overproduction. Reduces inventory waste.                                 |
| <b>Circular Fashion</b>                  | Garments designed for repair, resale, or recycling. Brands run take-back programs. Fabrics designed for closed-loop recycling.      |
| <b>Nearshoring</b>                       | Moving production closer to home markets to reduce shipping emissions and increase supply chain agility and speed.                  |
| <b>Bio-Based Materials</b>               | New fibers from algae, mycelium (mushroom), and food waste replacing petroleum-based synthetics.                                    |

**The most successful fashion brands of the next decade will treat sustainability as a core business model — not a marketing strategy.**

# Chapter 12: Conclusion & Next Steps

## Your Journey Starts Here

You have now completed a comprehensive journey through the world of clothing manufacturing — from understanding fabric types and production models to mastering quality control, navigating export logistics, leveraging digital tools, and building a sustainable brand. This knowledge is the foundation every successful fashion entrepreneur needs.

The clothing industry is complex — but it is not impenetrable. Every great fashion brand started with a single idea, a single garment, a single order. What separates the brands that succeed from those that do not is knowledge, preparation, and the right manufacturing partner.

## Key Takeaways

- Choose the right production model — OEM, ODM, Private Label, or CMT — based on your budget, timeline, and goals
- Invest in a complete, detailed tech pack before approaching any factory
- Know your fabrics — GSM, certifications, and sustainability credentials matter for your market and your customers
- Quality control at multiple stages — not just at the end — is what separates professional production from costly disasters
- Plan your logistics early — freight bookings, export documents, and customs requirements cannot be left to the last minute
- Build sustainability into your brand from day one — [EPR 2026](#) is coming and your customers are already demanding it
- Use all available tools and calculators at [sdfitd.com](#) to plan your costs and timelines accurately
- Communicate clearly and in writing at every stage of production — every decision must be documented
- Choose a manufacturing partner who understands startup brands, supports your growth, and grows with you

## How SDF Clothing Supports Your Brand

SDF Clothing has been manufacturing garments for global fashion brands since 1998 — over 25 years of production excellence. With a vertically integrated facility in Dhaka handling everything from fabric sourcing and sample development to bulk production, embroidery, printing, packaging, and export documentation — all under one roof, with no outsourcing — SDF Clothing is the ideal partner for startup brands ready to build something real.

|                |                                                                                        |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Low MOQ        | Starting from 300 pieces per style — accessible for first-time brands and design tests |
| Design Support | Tech pack development from rough sketches. Bespoke consultation for first orders.      |

|                          |                                                                                   |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Certified Fabrics</b> | GOTS, OEKO-TEX, GRS certified options. Full certification documentation provided. |
| <b>Fast Samples</b>      | First sample in 14 days. Up to 10 revisions. Free for confirmed orders.           |
| <b>End-to-End</b>        | Fabric, CMT, print, embroidery, wash, packaging, and export under one roof.       |
| <b>Export Expertise</b>  | FOB shipping from Chittagong and Dhaka. Full export documentation included.       |
| <b>Duty-Free</b>         | Zero-tariff access to EU, UK, and Canada. Significant cost advantage vs China.    |
| <b>Ethical</b>           | BSCI, SEDEX certified. GOTS organic. OEKO-TEX compliant. ETP for wastewater.      |

**Ready to build your clothing brand? Contact SDF Clothing for a free consultation and quote.**

**GET YOUR FREE QUOTE IN 48 HOURS**



[www.sdf ltd.com](http://www.sdf ltd.com)



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# Glossary of Key Terms

A quick reference guide to the most important terms used throughout this eBook and in the clothing manufacturing industry.

|                                       |                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>AQL (Acceptable Quality Level)</b> | Statistical standard for inspection sampling. AQL 2.5 is the fashion industry norm. |
| <b>B/L (Bill of Lading)</b>           | Shipping document issued by carrier. Proof of shipment. Required to claim goods.    |
| <b>BSCI</b>                           | Business Social Compliance Initiative. Ethical supply chain standard.               |
| <b>CBM (Cubic Meter)</b>              | Volume measurement for sea freight cargo.                                           |
| <b>CIF</b>                            | Cost, Insurance, Freight. Incoterm where seller pays shipping and insurance.        |
| <b>CMT</b>                            | Cut, Make, Trim. Core garment production process.                                   |
| <b>CO (Certificate of Origin)</b>     | Document proving where goods were manufactured.                                     |
| <b>DDP</b>                            | Delivered Duty Paid. Incoterm where seller delivers to buyer's door, duties paid.   |
| <b>DCTS</b>                           | Developing Countries Trading Scheme (UK). Duty-free access for Bangladesh.          |
| <b>DTF</b>                            | Direct to Film. Modern full-color print transfer technique.                         |
| <b>DTG</b>                            | Direct to Garment. Inkjet printing directly onto fabric.                            |
| <b>DWR</b>                            | Durable Water Repellent. Coating for outerwear performance fabrics.                 |
| <b>EBA</b>                            | Everything But Arms. EU duty-free initiative for least developed countries.         |
| <b>EPR</b>                            | Extended Producer Responsibility. EU 2026 textile take-back regulation.             |
| <b>ETP</b>                            | Effluent Treatment Plant. Wastewater treatment facility in textile factories.       |
| <b>FCL</b>                            | Full Container Load. Entire shipping container rented for one shipment.             |
| <b>FOB</b>                            | Free on Board. Seller loads goods at port; buyer takes risk from that point.        |
| <b>GOTS</b>                           | Global Organic Textile Standard. Organic fabric certification.                      |
| <b>GRS</b>                            | Global Recycled Standard. Certifies recycled content in materials.                  |

|                 |                                                                                 |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>GSM</b>      | Grams per Square Meter. Standard measure of fabric weight.                      |
| <b>GSP</b>      | Generalized System of Preferences. Trade program for duty reductions.           |
| <b>HS Code</b>  | Harmonized System Code. International product classification for customs.       |
| <b>LCL</b>      | Less than Container Load. Shared container for smaller shipments.               |
| <b>LDCT</b>     | Least Developed Country Tariff. Canada's duty-free access for Bangladesh.       |
| <b>MOQ</b>      | Minimum Order Quantity. Smallest number of pieces a factory will produce.       |
| <b>ODM</b>      | Original Design Manufacturer. Factory provides designs; brand applies branding. |
| <b>OEM</b>      | Original Equipment Manufacturer. Brand provides designs; factory produces.      |
| <b>OEKO-TEX</b> | International testing and certification for textile safety.                     |
| <b>PPS</b>      | Pre-Production Sample. Final approval sample before bulk production begins.     |
| <b>rPET</b>     | Recycled Polyester. Made from post-consumer plastic bottles.                    |
| <b>SA8000</b>   | Social Accountability standard for labor rights and working conditions.         |
| <b>SEDEX</b>    | Supplier Ethical Data Exchange. Supply chain ethical monitoring platform.       |
| <b>SMS</b>      | Salesman Sample. Production-quality sample used for buying meetings.            |
| <b>TT</b>       | Telegraphic Transfer. International bank wire payment.                          |
| <b>YKK</b>      | World's largest zipper manufacturer. Industry standard for premium zippers.     |